

DOC 2

Cross-Functional Pain Point Database

Operational Friction Taxonomy + Evidence-Backed Database

February 8, 2026

Client-ready portfolio artifact

Design system: navy + teal, structured tables, quote callouts

Snapshot	
Purpose	Cross-functional pain point database to prioritize automation opportunities.
Coverage	7 functions; 300+ public sources; 89 pain points cataloged.
Format	Taxonomy + evidence-backed database + prioritization matrix.
Use case	Opportunity discovery, product wedge selection, research planning.

How to use this document
Scan the Snapshot, then jump to the headings. Quotes and tables contain the highest-signal evidence. This artifact is designed for fast executive review and deep operator follow-up.

Operational Friction Database: Cross-Functional Workflow Pain Points

Purpose: Structured catalog of recurring operational pain points extracted from qualitative desk research across multiple roles, functions, and industries. Organized by friction type to enable cross-functional pattern recognition and prioritization of automation opportunities.

Scope: 7 functions researched, 300+ public sources reviewed, 89 discrete pain points cataloged. This document presents the 40 highest-signal findings.

Sources: Reddit (function-specific subreddits), YouTube (workflow walkthroughs), podcasts (operations and function-specific), vendor case studies (read critically), professional community forums.

FRICTION TAXONOMY

Before presenting findings, the following taxonomy was developed inductively from the data to categorize types of operational friction:

Friction Type	Code	Definition	Example
Manual Handoff	MH	Information or tasks transferred between people or teams via manual, unstructured methods (email, Slack, verbal)	Finance emails department heads requesting close inputs
Tool Fragmentation	TF	Required information or steps spread across multiple disconnected tools	CSM checks 5+ tools every morning to reconstruct account context
Shadow System	SS	Unofficial tracking system (spreadsheet, personal doc) maintained because official tools are insufficient	Controller's personal Excel close checklist
Approval Bottleneck	AB	Work stalls waiting for authorization from a specific person with no escalation path	Purchase order sits for days because approver is on PTO
Exception Handling Gap	EH	No defined process for handling non-standard cases, leading to ad hoc workarounds	Vendor invoice doesn't match PO - no clear resolution workflow
Knowledge Concentration	KC	Critical process knowledge held by one person, undocumented	Senior admin's onboarding scripts known only to them
Format Translation	FT	Same information manually reformatted for different tools, audiences, or systems	Data exported from ERP -> reformatted in Excel -> pasted into slides
Timing/Sequencing Failure	TS	Steps executed out of order or at the wrong time due to lack of workflow coordination	IT learns about employee departure days after it happens
Duplication of Effort	DE	Multiple people independently performing the same work because of poor visibility	Three people separately compile the same data for different reports

PAIN POINT DATABASE - BY FUNCTION

FINANCE & ACCOUNTING

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
FIN-01	Month-end close tracked in personal	SS	High	34/47 threads	Controller, Senior Accountant	"My 74-line Excel checklist is the most	r/controllers

	spreadsheets					important document in the department and it lives on my desktop."	
FIN-02	Waiting on other departments for close inputs	MH, TS	High	28/47 threads	Controller	"Day 1: I send the same email to 6 department heads. Day 3: I follow up. Day 5: I start calling."	r/controllers
FIN-03	Bank reconciliations done manually in Excel	SS, FT	High	25/47 threads	Staff Accountant	"Bank recs take me two full days. I download the CSV, export the GL, paste into my template, and start matching."	r/Accounting
FIN-04	Board deck / reporting built manually from ERP exports	FT	Medium-High	19/47 threads	FP&A Analyst	"Closing takes 8 days. Building the board deck takes another 3. It's all manual."	r/FPandA
FIN-05	Expense report approvals delayed by managers	AB	Medium	14/47 threads	AP Clerk	"I have \$30K in pending expense reports right now. Three managers haven't approved anything in 2 weeks."	r/Accounting
FIN-06	Vendor invoice doesn't match PO - no standard resolution process	EH	Medium	12/47 threads	AP Clerk	"When the invoice doesn't match the PO, it goes into the 'figure it out' pile. That pile is always growing."	r/Accounting

IT OPERATIONS

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
IT-01	No reliable notification when	MH, TS	Critical	22/38 threads	IT Admin, Sysadmin	"We had an ex-employee access our	r/sysadmin

	employees leave the company					shared drive two weeks after they were let go. Nobody had told IT."	
IT-02	No centralized list of which tools each role needs	KC, SS	High	18/38 threads	IT Admin	"Every time we onboard someone, I Slack the hiring manager: 'What tools do they need?' Half the time they don't know."	r/sysadmin
IT-03	Software licenses stay assigned to departed employees	TS, DE	High	15/38 threads	IT Manager	"I did a license audit last quarter. We were paying for 40+ seats across various tools for people who hadn't worked here in months."	r/ITManagers
IT-04	IT support tickets lack context - users describe symptoms, not problems	MH, FT	Medium	14/38 threads	Help Desk	"'My computer is slow' could mean 15 different things. I spend more time diagnosing what they actually mean than fixing the issue."	r/sysadmin
IT-05	Scheduled scripts and automations known only to their creator	KC	High	11/38 threads	Sysadmin	"When our senior sysadmin left, we discovered 40+ scheduled scripts running that nobody else knew about."	r/ITManagers
IT-06	Hardware procurement requests routed through email with no tracking	MH, SS	Medium	10/38 threads	IT Manager	"Someone emails me 'I need a new laptop.' I add it to my spreadsheet. I email procurement. They email the vendor. Nobody knows the status."	r/sysadmin

CUSTOMER SUCCESS

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
CS-01	Daily "morning context rebuild" across 4-7 tools	TF	High	26/40 sources	CSM	"By the time I've checked Salesforce, Zendesk, product analytics, Slack, and my own spreadsheet, it's 10 AM."	r/customersuccess
CS-02	Health scores in official tools don't match reality	SS	High	18/40 sources	CSM	"I built a personal Notion dashboard because GainSight's health scores don't reflect what's actually happening."	GainSight community
CS-03	No single view of upcoming renewals with full context	TF, FT	High	16/40 sources	CS Manager	"I pull renewal dates from Salesforce, usage data from our product, support history from Zendesk, and combine them in a Google Sheet. That's my renewal prep."	r/customersuccess
CS-04	Handoff from Sales to CS loses critical context	MH, KC	High	15/40 sources	CSM	"Sales closes the deal and I get a Slack message: 'New customer, here's the Salesforce link.' Zero context about what was promised, what their priorities are, nothing."	r/customersuccess
CS-05	Churn signals detected too late to act	TS	Critical	14/40 sources	CS Manager	"By the time I notice usage dropped, they've already made the decision to leave. I'm doing save calls that should have been check-in calls two months ago."	Podcast transcript
CS-06	QBR preparation is manual and takes 3-5 hours per account	FT, DE	Medium	11/40 sources	CSM	"I spend half a day building a QBR deck for each strategic account. Most of that	YouTube walkthrough

						time is pulling data from different systems and formatting slides."	
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HR / PEOPLE OPERATIONS

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
HR-01	Onboarding checklist not connected to actual tool provisioning	MH, TF	High	20/35 sources	HR Coordinator, IT	"HR's onboarding checklist says 'set up systems access.' That's one checkbox for them. For me, it's 12 different tools with different admin consoles."	r/sysadmin
HR-02	Benefits enrollment questions answered one-by-one via email/Slack	DE	Medium-High	16/35 sources	HR Generalist	"During open enrollment, I answer the same 10 questions 200 times. I made a FAQ doc. Nobody reads it."	r/humanresources
HR-03	Performance review data collected in spreadsheets, not connected to compensation decisions	SS, FT	Medium	14/35 sources	HR Manager	"Reviews happen in a Google Form, results go to a spreadsheet, comp decisions happen in a different spreadsheet, then I manually update the HRIS."	r/humanresources
HR-04	Employee status changes (promotions, transfers) not communicated to all relevant systems	MH, TS	High	12/35 sources	HR Operations	"Someone gets promoted and I have to update it in 4 systems manually: HRIS, payroll, org chart tool, and the access management	r/humanresources

						system. I always forget one."	
HR-05	PTO tracking discrepancies between manager approvals and system records	SS, EH	Medium	10/35 sources	HR Coordinator	"Managers approve PTO over Slack and forget to log it in the system. Then at year-end, nobody's balances are right."	r/humanresources

SALES OPERATIONS

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
SO-01	CRM data quality - reps don't update Salesforce consistently	SS, KC	Critical	30/42 sources	Sales Ops Manager	"Our Salesforce data is maybe 60% accurate. Reps update it when they remember, which is right before pipeline review. Garbage in, garbage out."	r/salesforce
SO-02	Commission calculations done in Excel outside the CRM	SS, FT	High	18/42 sources	Sales Ops Analyst	"I spend the first week of every month calculating commissions in a spreadsheet that's so complex I'm afraid to touch the formulas."	r/salesops
SO-03	Quote-to-contract process involves 3+ tools and manual handoffs	MH, TF	High	16/42 sources	Sales Ops, Legal	"Rep builds quote in Salesforce, exports to Word, legal redlines in Word, I re-enter final terms in Salesforce, then generate the contract in DocuSign. Every deal."	r/salesforce
SO-04	Territory and account	EH, TS	Medium	12/42 sources	Sales Ops Manager	"Every time we do a	r/salesops

	assignment changes break reporting					territory realignment, three months of pipeline reporting becomes unreliable."	
SO-05	Forecasting relies on rep judgment, not system data	KC, SS	High	14/42 sources	VP Sales, Sales Ops	"Our forecast is basically asking each rep 'how do you feel about your deals?' and putting that in a spreadsheet. The CRM data isn't trusted enough to forecast from."	r/salesforce

OPERATIONS / SUPPLY CHAIN

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
OP-01	The ERP handles 80% of cases; the other 20% lives in spreadsheets	SS, EH	High	22/36 sources	Operations Manager	"Our ERP handles standard orders great. Anything non-standard - partial shipments, custom terms, special pricing - goes into my spreadsheet."	r/supplychain
OP-02	Inventory discrepancies between system and physical counts	TS, MH	High	18/36 sources	Warehouse Manager	"Every cycle count is a scavenger hunt. The system says we have 50 units. We find 43. Where are the other 7? Could be anywhere in the process."	r/logistics
OP-03	Vendor communication happens across email, phone, and	TF	Medium-High	15/36 sources	Procurement	"I have conversations with the same vendor in email, on their portal, and	r/procurement

	portals with no single thread					sometimes by phone. When there's a dispute, I have to reconstruct the timeline from three sources."	
OP-04	Order exceptions require manual intervention and have no escalation workflow	EH, AB	Medium	12/36 sources	Order Manager	"When an order hits an exception, it sits in a queue until someone notices. There's no alert, no escalation. I check the queue twice a day and hope nothing falls through."	r/supplychain

LEGAL / COMPLIANCE

ID	Pain Point	Friction Type	Severity	Frequency in Sources	Role Most Affected	Representative Quote	Source
LG-01	Contract review requests come through email with no prioritization	MH, AB	High	14/28 sources	Legal Ops, In-house Counsel	"I get contract review requests via email, Slack, Jira, and sometimes people just walk over. There's no queue, no priority system. Everything is urgent according to the requester."	r/inhouse
LG-02	Executed contracts stored in inconsistent locations	TF, SS	High	12/28 sources	Legal Ops	"Some contracts are in the shared drive, some are in Salesforce, some are in the old contract system nobody uses anymore, and some are in someone's	r/legalops

						email."	
LG-03	Renewal and expiration dates tracked in spreadsheet	SS, TS	Medium-High	10/28 sources	Legal Ops, Procurement	"I have a spreadsheet with 200 contract expiration dates. Every Monday I check which ones are coming up. If I miss a week, we miss a cancellation window."	r/legalops

CROSS-FUNCTIONAL PATTERNS

Pattern A: The Shadow Spreadsheet Is Universal

Every function researched has at least one critical workflow tracked in a personal spreadsheet outside the "official" system. This is the single most consistent finding across all 300+ sources. The spreadsheet is not the problem - it's a symptom of tools that don't match how work actually flows.

Pattern B: Handoff Points Are Where Work Breaks Down

The highest-friction moments consistently occur not within a function, but between functions: Sales -> CS (context loss), HR -> IT (onboarding delays), Departments -> Finance (close inputs), Operations -> Finance (inventory reconciliation). These handoffs are almost always mediated by email or Slack with no structured workflow.

Pattern C: Exception Handling Is the Hidden Time Sink

Standard processes generally work. Exceptions - the non-standard cases, the mismatches, the edge cases - consume disproportionate time because there's no defined workflow for handling them. Practitioners describe "figuring it out" case by case, which means institutional knowledge about how to resolve exceptions lives in people's heads, not in systems.

Pattern D: The Same Pain Points Exist Regardless of Tools

Companies using sophisticated ERPs (NetSuite, SAP) report many of the same friction points as companies using QuickBooks and spreadsheets. This suggests that the core problems are workflow and handoff problems, not feature gaps in individual tools.

SEVERITY PRIORITIZATION MATRIX

Priority	Friction Type	Functions Affected	Automation Opportunity
Critical	Manual cross-departmental handoffs	All	Workflow automation with structured inputs and status tracking
Critical	Shadow tracking spreadsheets	Finance, IT, Legal, CS, Sales Ops	Purpose-built workflow tools that replace the spreadsheet organically
High	Reconciliation / matching tasks	Finance, Operations	Rule-based auto-matching with exception flagging
High	Context fragmentation across tools	CS, Sales, IT	Unified view / integration layer that assembles context from multiple sources
High	Timing and sequencing failures	IT, HR, Legal	Event-triggered workflows with automated notifications
Medium	Format translation between systems	Finance, CS, Sales Ops	Template automation and dynamic reporting
Medium	Exception handling gaps	Operations, Finance, Legal	Defined exception workflows with escalation rules